Even as Ceausescu and Honecker enjoyed their tête-à-tête, the wind of change howled across Eastern Europe. During November, the Supreme Soviet of the Estonian SSR adopted the ‘Estonian Sovereignty Declaration’, in which local laws were declared supreme over those of the Soviet Union, the first declaration of sovereignty from Moscow of any Soviet or Eastern Bloc entity. In response Moscow declared it unconstitutional, but in a two-fingered salute, reformers pushed on and even replaced Russian as the nation’s official language.

At a conference of the SED Central Committee in December, Honecker again spoke out against perestroika, thus confirming his place as the leader of a small band of extreme Stalinist leaders. In private, he poured out attack after attack on those who would seek to weaken the GDR. His main target was Gorbachev.